Muslim population. While Pakistani leaders were confident that Kashmir would fall into their laps, the Maharaja and the popular National Conference political party of Sheikh Abdullah were disinclined to join Pakistan. As the Maharaja considered holding out for independence, local leaders in Poonch who wished to join Pakistan rebelled, and they soon began to receive support from Pakistan. In late October 1947, Pakistani tribal militia or *lashkars*—backed by the state—seized towns in western Kashmir. The Maharaja panicked, signed the Instrument of Accession with India, and sought military assistance. Air lifted Indian forces arrived in Srinagar just in time to stop the advancing irregular forces from Pakistan, and thereby saved the Kashmir Valley for India. [20]

As fighting continued, Jinnah initially expressed opposition to a plebiscite, a public referendum on the fate of Jammu and Kashmir. He may have believed that the tribal invasion into Kashmir would succeed, or that it would weaken Hyderabad's case for independence, and possibly that a vote would not go in Pakistan's favour given the looting and rape by the Pakistani *lashkars*. After an escalation in fighting, the situation had stabilized by January 1948, when India made a fateful decision to approach the United Nations. Although Nehru had been confident that India could make a strong case in its favour, Britain's delegation supported a plebiscite in the presence of Pakistani troops and a 'neutral' administration (i.e. not led by Sheikh Abdullah), a position that was mostly in line with Pakistan. These moves were compounded by measures advanced by Belgium and Canada that did not prevent Pakistan from assisting the invaders and widened the dispute to one between India and Pakistan. Meanwhile, in response to concerns that the Indian Army would advance beyond the Uri–Poonch–Naushera line, the Pakistan Army became directly involved in the conflict in Kashmir in April 1948. [21]

In August 1948, a UN Commission concluded a three-part resolution that called for a ceasefire; the removal of Pakistani troops and thereafter a staged withdrawal of the bulk of Indian forces, with only a residual presence to maintain law and order; and consultations to determine conditions for settling Kashmir based on 'the will of the people'. Pakistan